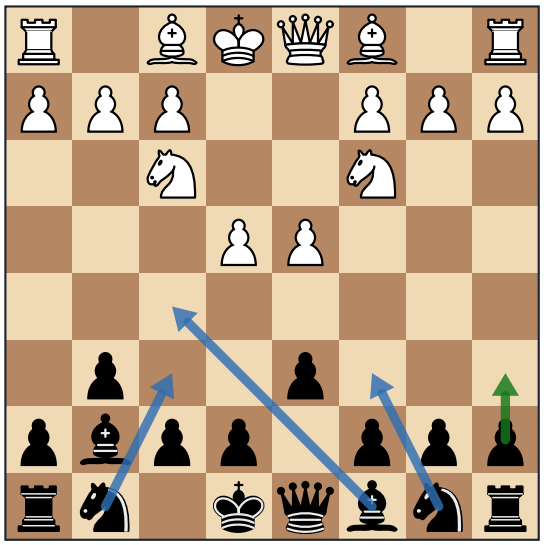
Modern Defense

ECO A04-B27 | 39 named lines | Semi-open / hypermodern defenses

In one sentence: Hypermodern and semi-open defenses avoid book fights: Black lets White build, then counterattacks the center.

Memory pattern: Let White build, then hit the center with ...c5 or ...e5.



Main line: 1.e4 g6 2.d4 Bg7 3.Nc3 d6 4.Nf3

Key ideas

1. Black fianchettoes (Pirc/Modern) or hits e4 at once (Scandinavian, Alekhine).
2. White gets space and often a big center, but it can become a target.
3. Black's key breaks are ...c5, ...e5 and ...f5 at the right moment.
4. Develop quickly and avoid early queen moves unless they win time.
5. White should avoid overextension and keep pieces coordinated.

Reading the diagram

Blue arrows = thematic plan moves for the side to move. Green arrow = engine's best move.
Engine at the end of the main line: **+0.64** (slightly better for White, depth 15). Best: a6.

The five coach questions

1. Ideal pawn structure?	Black avoids symmetrical development: a fianchetto (Pirc/Modern), a quick ...d5 (Scandinavian) or tempo play (Alekhine). White often gets a big center.
2. Where does my king go?	Black castles short behind the fianchetto; White often attacks with f4/Be3/Qd2/h4.
3. Best minor pieces?	Black: Bg7, Nf6/Nd7, ...c5/...e5 breaks. White: Nc3, Nf3, Be3, Bc4.
4. Main middlegame plan?	Black waits, then undermines the center with ...c5 or ...e5; White consolidates the center and develops quickly.
5. What does my opponent want?	White wants a big center and a fast attack; Black wants to hit the center in time.

The main line, move by move

Most common continuation in the database: 1.e4 g6 2.d4 Bg7 3.Nc3 d6 4.Nf3

Move	Why it is played
1. e4	Occupies the center with a pawn.
1... g6	Fianchetto. Gains space on the wing.
2. d4	Take the center. Occupies the center with a pawn.
2... Bg7	Long diagonal. Fianchetto: the bishop takes the long diagonal.
3. Nc3	Develops the knight to c3.
3... d6	Support. Pawn move that supports the center or prepares a break.
4. Nf3	Develops the knight to f3.



After 1.e4 g6 2.d4 Bg7

Key variations

The most important named branches (ranked by how much theory lies beneath them). Diagram arrows: blue = plan moves, green = Stockfish.

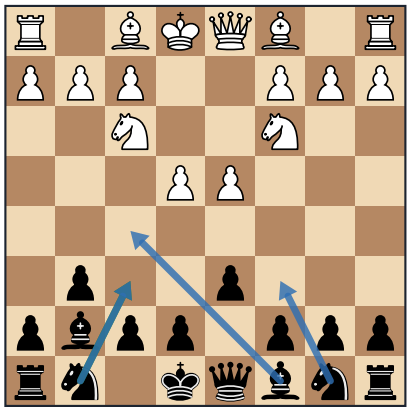


Position after the line

Bishop Attack B06 | 3 lines

`1.e4 g6 2.d4 Bg7 3.Bc4`

Stockfish: **+0.44** (slightly better for White, depth 18). Best next move: c6.
What to look for: Nf6 (hit e4); g6 (fianchetto); Bg7 (long diagonal)
Sub-variations: Bücker Gambit, Monkey's Bum



Position after the line

Two Knights Variation B06 | 3 lines

`1.e4 g6 2.d4 Bg7 3.Nc3 d6 4.Nf3`

Stockfish: **+0.67** (slightly better for White, depth 14). Best next move: Nf6.
What to look for: Nf6 (hit e4); g6 (fianchetto); Bg7 (long diagonal)
Sub-variations: Suttles Variation



Position after the line

Mongredien Defense B06 | 2 lines

`1.e4 g6 2.d4 Bg7`

Stockfish: **+0.65** (slightly better for White, depth 15). Best next move: Nf3.
What to look for: Nc3 (develop); Nf3 (develop); d4 (take the center)
Sub-variations: with Nc3, with Nf3

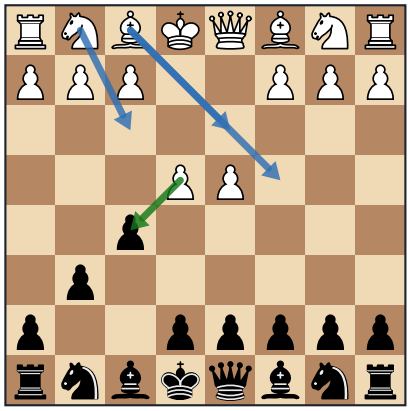


Position after the line

Norwegian Defense B06 | 2 lines

`1.e4 g6 2.d4 Nf6`

Stockfish: **+1.19** (clearly better for White, depth 16). Best next move: e5.
What to look for: Nc3 (develop); Nf3 (develop); d4 (take the center)
Sub-variations: Norwegian Gambit

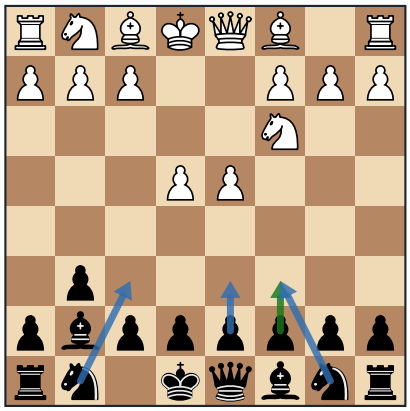


Position after the line

Fianchetto Gambit B06 | 1 lines

`1.e4 g6 2.d4 f5`

Stockfish: **+1.98** (clearly better for White, depth 15). Best next move: exf5.
What to look for: Nc3 (develop); Nf3 (develop); d4 (take the center)



Position after the line

Standard Line B06 | 1 lines

`1.e4 g6 2.d4 Bg7 3.Nc3`

Stockfish: **+0.58** (slightly better for White, depth 16). Best next move: c6.
What to look for: Nf6 (hit e4); g6 (fianchetto); Bg7 (long diagonal)

Expert and coach view

What a coach would tell you

Know the move-order tricks: in the Pirc, White's Austrian Attack (f4) is the main danger; in the Scandinavian, learn the queen retreat squares (a5, d6, d8). Always counterattack the center within the first 8-10 moves.

Why play it

Hypermodern and semi-open defenses avoid book fights: Black lets White build, then counterattacks the center.

Typical mistakes

- Letting White roll forward with e5 and f4 without a counter-break.
- Moving the queen repeatedly in the Scandinavian and falling behind in development.
- Fianchettoing without castling early and leaving the king exposed.

Typical tactics and traps

- Bxf7+ or Bxh7+ if Black's king sits behind a fianchetto without defenders.
- e5 forks or pins after Black ignores the center.

Endgame and middlegame outlook

Black aims to undermine White's center and reach an equal middlegame with flexible pawn structure.

Study checklist

[ ] Play the main line on a board and say each move's purpose aloud.

[ ] Learn the five coach questions by heart; answer them without notes.

[ ] Drill two sub-variations until the moves feel automatic.

[ ] Play three games with the opening, then review where you left theory.

[ ] Re-read the traps page the day before a tournament.

The opening tree

Every named line in this family as a tree. Gray moves are inherited from the parent; green after the arrow are the new moves that define the variation. Large green dots mark branches with 10 or more lines.

- **Modern Defense (all lines)** — B06
  `1.e4 g6`
  - **Lizard Defense** — A40
    - **Pirc-Diemer Gambit** — A40
      `1.d4 g6 2.h4 Nf6 3.h5`
    - **Mittenberger Gambit** — B06
      `1.e4 g6 2.d4 Bg7 3.Nc3 d5`
  - **Semi-Averbakh Variation** — A04
    - **Polish Variation** — A04
      `1.Nf3 c5 2.c4 g6 3.d4 Bg7 4.e4 Qb6`
    - **Pterodactyl Variation** — A04
      `1.Nf3 c5 2.c4 g6 3.d4 Bg7 4.e4 Qa5`
    - **Pterodactyl Variation Accepted** — A04
      `1.Nf3 g6 2.d4 Bg7 3.e4 d6 4.c4 c5 5.dxc5 Qa5`
    - **Pterodactyl Variation Declined** — B06
      `1.e4 g6 2.d4 Bg7 3.c4 c5 4.Nf3 d6 5.Be2 Qa5`
  - **Fianchetto Gambit** — B06
    `1.e4 g6 -> 2.d4 f5`
  - **Mongredien Defense** — B06
    `1.e4 g6 -> 2.d4 Bg7`
    - **with Nc3** — B06
      `1.e4 g6 2.d4 Bg7 -> 3.Nc3 b6`
    - **with Nf3** — B06
      `1.e4 g6 2.d4 Bg7 -> 3.Nf3 b6`
  - **Norwegian Defense** — B06
    `1.e4 g6 -> 2.d4 Nf6`
    - **Norwegian Gambit** — B06
      `1.e4 g6 2.d4 Nf6 -> 3.e5 Nh5 4.Be2 d6`
  - **Bishop Attack** — B06
    `1.e4 g6 -> 2.d4 Bg7 3.Bc4`
    - **Bücker Gambit** — B06
      `1.e4 g6 2.d4 Bg7 3.Bc4 -> 3...b5`
    - **Monkey's Bum** — B06
      `1.e4 g6 2.Bc4 Bg7 3.Qf3 e6 4.d4 Bxd4`
  - **Standard Line** — B06
    `1.e4 g6 -> 2.d4 Bg7 3.Nc3`
  - **Three Pawns Attack** — B06
    `1.e4 g6 -> 2.d4 Bg7 3.f4`
  - **Westermann Gambit** — B06
    `1.e4 g6 -> 2.d4 Bg7 3.Bd2`
  - **Wind Gambit** — B06
    `1.e4 g6 -> 2.d4 Bg7 3.Bd3`
  - **Modern Pterodactyl** — B06
    `1.e4 g6 -> 2.d4 Bg7 3.Nc3 c5`
  - **Neo-Modern Defense** — A41
    `1.d4 g6 2.c4 Bg7 3.e4 e5`
  - **Standard Defense** — B06
    `1.e4 g6 -> 2.d4 Bg7 3.Nc3 d6`
  - **Averbakh System** — A42
    `1.d4 g6 2.c4 Bg7 3.Nc3 d6 4.e4`
  - **Geller's System** — B07
    `1.e4 g6 -> 2.d4 Bg7 3.Nf3 d6 4.c3`
  - **Pseudo-Austrian Attack** — B06
    `1.e4 g6 -> 2.d4 Bg7 3.Nc3 d6 4.f4`
  - **Two Knights Variation** — B06
    `1.e4 g6 -> 2.d4 Bg7 3.Nc3 d6 4.Nf3`

- **Suttles Variation** B06
  1.e4 g6 2.d4 Bg7 3.Nc3 c6 4.Nf3 d6
  - **Tal Gambit** B06
    1.e4 g6 2.d4 Bg7 3.Nc3 d6 4.Nf3 c6 5.Bg5 Qb6 6.Qd2 Qxb2
- **Kotov Variation** A42
  1.d4 g6 2.c4 Bg7 3.Nc3 d6 4.e4 Nc6
- **Pterodactyl Variation** B27
  1.e4 c5 2.Nf3 g6 3.d4 Bg7 4.Nc3 Qa5
- **Randspringer Variation** A42
  1.d4 g6 2.c4 Bg7 3.Nc3 d6 4.e4 f5
- **Anti-Modern** B06
  1.e4 g6 -> 2.d4 Bg7 3.Nc3 c6 4.Bc4 d6 5.Qe2
- **Averbakh Variation** A42
  1.d4 g6 2.c4 Bg7 3.e4 d6 4.Be3 Nf6 5.f3
  - **Pseudo-Sämisch** A42
    1.d4 g6 2.c4 Bg7 3.e4 d6 4.Be3 Nf6 5.f3
- **Beefeater Variation** A40
  1.d4 g6 2.c4 Bg7 3.Nc3 c5 4.d5 Bxc3 5.bxc3 f5
- **Dunworthy Variation** B06
  1.e4 g6 -> 2.d4 Bg7 3.c4 d5 4.exd5 c6 5.dxc6 Bxd4
- **Gurgenidze Defense** B06
  1.e4 g6 -> 2.d4 Bg7 3.Nc3 c6 4.f4 d5 5.e5 h5
- **Masur Gambit** B06
  1.e4 g6 -> 2.d4 Nh6 3.Nc3 f5 4.Bxh6 Bxh6 5.exf5 O-O

One-page memory sheet

Move-order pattern

```
1.e4 g6 2.d4 Bg7 3.Nc3 d6 4.Nf3
```

Plan chain

White	Nc3 -> Nf3 -> d4 -> Bd2 -> Bc4
Black	Nf6 -> g6 -> Bg7 -> d6 -> c6

Three rules to remember

1. Let White build, then hit the center with ...c5 or ...e5.

2. Black waits, then undermines the center with ...c5 or ...e5; White consolidates the center and develops quickly.

3. White wants a big center and a fast attack; Black wants to hit the center in time.

Pawn structure in one line

Black avoids symmetrical development: a fianchetto (Pirc/Modern), a quick ...d5 (Scandinavian) or tempo play (Alekhine). White often gets a big center.